

National Research University Higher School of Economics

Social Network Analysis

**Exploration of code-switching in Tatarstan and Yakutia through an
analysis of regional social media**

students

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Introduction

This research explores the phenomenon of code-switching in two multilingual regions of the Russian Federation, the Republic of Tatarstan and the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia), through the analysis of regional social media data. Code-switching, defined as the alternation between two or more languages within a single communicative situation, is a widespread practice in polycultural societies and serves as a reflection of complex social, political, and linguistic dynamics. Understanding how users navigate between languages in digital spaces provides valuable insights into contemporary bilingual and multilingual identities, language vitality, and the impact of state language policies. The Republic of Tatarstan, located in the Volga Federal District, is home to approximately 4 million people, with Tatars comprising 53.2 percent of the population and Russians 39.7 percent according to the latest census. The republic has two state languages, Russian and Tatar, and has implemented state supported polylingual education programs that aim to create equal conditions for instruction in Tatar, Russian, and English. In contrast, the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia), situated in the Far Eastern Federal District, covers more than 3 million square kilometers and has a population of approximately 1,013,700 people as of 2026. The region recognizes Sakha (Yakut) and Russian as state languages, while five indigenous languages including Evenki, Even, Yukaghir, Dolgan, and Chukchi have official status in places of compact residence. The linguistic landscape of Yakutia is characterized by a transition from historical Yakut indigenous bilingualism to a complex trilingual model involving Yakut, Russian, and indigenous languages, though the functioning of smaller indigenous languages is increasingly minimal. The use of Russian, English, Tatar, and Yakut languages in these regions reflects different historical, demographic, and policy contexts. In Tatarstan, Russian and Tatar coexist in a model of balanced bilingualism that is increasingly showing signs of divergence between Russian speaking urban populations and Tatar speaking rural communities. English serves as a third language, with growing demand for business English linked to the republic's expanding international economic ties. In Yakutia, Russian dominates official and administrative spheres, while Yakut functions as a language of interethnic communication particularly in rural areas. English appears predominantly in symbolic and decorative functions on urban signage in Yakutsk, perceived as "speech scenery" rather than as a fully functional communicative tool. Social media platforms, particularly VKontakte, provide a rich source of naturalistic data for examining how users in both regions employ these languages in spontaneous, unmonitored digital communication. In the practical part of this research, a graph based analysis will be constructed to model code-switching interactions among users in Tatarstan and Yakutia social media spaces. After constructing the directed graph, the analysis will be able to answer several key research questions. First, are there language isolates, or do Tatar speakers form a dense cluster in social media that Russian speakers do not enter? Second, what is the direction of asymmetry, does switching occur primarily from Russian to Tatar or from Tatar to Russian, and will the directed graph reveal the dominant direction? Third, what are the differences between the two republics, does the structure of the graph differ for Tatarstan and Yakutia, and which region shows higher mixing between language groups?

1. Literature review

1.1. Theoretical Foundations of Code Switching

Code-switching is the use of two or more languages within a single speech situation [17]. Code-switching occurs in multicultural societies worldwide and results from a combination of social, political, economic, and linguistic factors. It is increasingly studied by both foreign and domestic researchers, who focus on emotional, cognitive, and sociolinguistic reasons for its spread, as well as its manifestations in different speech situations [11]. Code-switching can express social identity, solidarity, or respect for cultural traditions. In countries like the US, UK, and Brazil, it is linked to migration and historical social formation. The mixing of English with local languages often leads to a third code [22].

In Russia, code-switching is becoming more relevant due to the interaction of Russian with national languages and the growing influence of English, highlighting the need for detailed study. Understanding code-switching improves intercultural communication and reduces language barriers. However, negative aspects include interlanguage interference and code-mixing. While some scholars distinguish between code-switching and code-mixing based on the degree of interference, there is no consensus. Phonetic, morphological, and grammatical changes can cause misunderstandings, excessive borrowings, and communication difficulties. Moreover, using code-switching or code-mixing in some speech situations may be inappropriate and lead to negative perceptions of unprofessionalism [27].

1.2. Linguistic and Sociolinguistic Profile of Tatarstan

First, the Tatarstan region was analyzed. Based on the official sources available, here is the factual information regarding the Republic of Tatarstan for 2026, presented as a single text. According to a comprehensive demographic analysis presented at the State Council Committee on Social Policy meeting in November 2025, the population of Tatarstan was projected to reach 4,019,600 people by the beginning of 2026 [37]. Despite declining birth rates, the population continues to grow due to migration inflow [37]. Official statistics show that the total fertility rate is estimated at 1.5 children per woman of childbearing age, which is significantly below the simple reproduction rate, and the average age of mothers is about 29.5 years [37]. In terms of marriage patterns, women most often marry between the ages of 20 and 24, while men marry between 25 and 29, and the planned average age for first marriage among young people is 24.9 years for men and 23.8 years for women [37]. The total divorce rate in Tatarstan in 2023 was 3.6 per mille, one of the lowest in the Volga Federal District, where the average was 4.2 per mille [37].

Regarding economic indicators for 2026, the State Council of Tatarstan discussed the results of socio-economic development, reporting that the gross regional product exceeded 5.7 trillion rubles with an increase of 102.9 percent [37]. The industrial production index reached 105.3 percent in the first quarter of 2026 compared to the same period of the previous year, while the volume of shipped goods reached 1.47 trillion rubles [37]. In the construction sector, the volume of work completed was 122.5 billion rubles, and 1.61 million square

meters of housing were put into operation, representing a growth of 6.8 percent [37]. The average monthly salary in the republic for January and February 2026 was 91,659 rubles, which represents an increase of 16.1 percent compared to the previous year, while real wages grew by 8.6 percent [37]. The labor force numbered 2.08 million people with an employment rate of 61.9 percent, and 3,600 unemployed individuals were officially registered, accounting for only 0.17 percent of the labor force [37]. Investments in fixed capital for the year 2025 reached 1.67 trillion rubles with a growth of 3.8 percent [37]. As of January 1, 2026, 185,500 small and medium-sized business entities were registered in the republic, with 685,600 employed and 447,000 self-employed citizens [37]. For official statistical publications, Tatarstanstat released its electronic catalog for 2026 in January 2026, containing detailed statistical information on the republic [38].

The language environment of Tatarstan was investigated next. The article by Bastrikov, Bastrikova, and Palekha presents a fragment of an analytical report on monitoring the functioning of the Russian language as one of the state languages in the system of social communication in the Republic of Tatarstan [12]. The analysis of the results showed that students performed best on spelling and punctuation tasks, which is explained by the attention given to these topics in secondary school [12]. The block related to text analysis and speech styles caused the fewest difficulties [12]. The greatest problems were identified in the knowledge of accentological norms, such as word stress in words like "бухгалтеров", "налита", "опломбировать", "диспансер", "исчерпав", and "сверлишь", as well as in lexical combinability, especially when dealing with vocabulary from the passive dictionary, and in morphological norms, including the declension of numerals, agreement of first and last names, and determining the gender of nouns [12]. Many morphologically correct forms seem foreign to students by ear due to the lack of an auditory indicator of correctness, and they often follow the principle of "I have not heard it, so it must be incorrect" [12].

Then we explored the situation with the English language in Tatarstan. In the Republic of Tatarstan, the study and use of English are embedded within a unique multilingual educational framework that also includes Russian and Tatar as the two official state languages of the republic [18]. A distinctive feature of the region is the implementation of state-supported polylingual education, as exemplified by the "Adymnar" educational complexes, which aim to create equal conditions for teaching in Tatar, Russian, and English and offer families a choice between polylingual, bilingual, or monolingual educational tracks [18]. The close interaction of the three languages in the educational space of language universities in Tatarstan leads to both positive and negative effects on the acquisition of English [18]. Research conducted with 132 first-year bachelor students at a language university in Kazan showed that students who already spoke Tatar as a native or second language found it easier to learn English, particularly noting that similar phonetic features and consonant sounds in Tatar and English facilitated the acquisition of English pronunciation and grammar [18]. 83 percent of students who had studied Tatar before university reported that Tatar positively influenced their English learning, citing similar sentence structures, the presence of auxiliary verbs, and shared phonetic elements as beneficial factors [18]. However, the study also identified negative influences, including

language interference, involuntary code switching between Russian, Tatar, and English, and the agglutinative nature of Tatar with its system of affixes, which has no parallel in English [18]. The multilingual approach is further supported by the fact that the Russian language, which is known to 86.4 percent of Sakha people and actively used by them, serves as a bridge language alongside Tatar in the process of learning English [18]. Beyond the educational domain, the demand for English in Tatarstan has a strong practical and economic dimension. According to data from the service "Avito Services," in September 2025, the overall demand for foreign language learning in the republic increased by 37 percent compared to August, with the most notable growth observed for Business English, which saw a 72 percent increase in requests across Tatarstan and a 75 percent increase in Kazan alone [37]. Experts attribute this surge to the intensification of business activity after the summer season and the expansion of the republic's international ties with countries in the Middle East and Asia [37]. This trend indicates that English is increasingly perceived not merely as a foreign language for general communication but as a practical tool for professional and economic integration [37].

The article by Krivosheeva studies teaching English to language university students in the multilingual environment of Tatarstan [18]. The research involved 132 students divided into two groups, those who already knew Tatar before university and those who started learning Tatar from scratch [18]. The results showed that students who previously knew Tatar found English easier to learn due to similar phonetics and sentence structures [18]. 83 percent of these students reported that Tatar positively influenced their English learning [18]. Even 52 percent of students without prior Tatar knowledge acknowledged benefits of multilingualism for cognitive flexibility [18]. However, 45 percent of students in the second group found English difficult to master [18]. Negative influences included language interference, involuntary code switching, and the agglutinative nature of Tatar [18]. The author concludes that the multilingual environment has a predominantly positive effect on learning English when teachers use similarities between languages while avoiding negative transfer[18].

1.3. Linguistic and Sociolinguistic Profile of Yakutia

Based on the official website of the Federal State Statistics Service for the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia), the page does not contain any data specifically for the year 2026 [36]. The most recent information available for download on that page is from 2025, including population estimates by municipal districts and urban districts as of January 1, 2025, average annual population figures for 2020 through 2024, population data by municipal formations from January 1, 2020 to January 1, 2025, and an assessment of the permanent population in places of traditional residence of indigenous small numbered peoples of the North [36].

According to official information from Sahastat published in April 2026, the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia) is the largest federal subject of Russia by area, covering more than 3 million square kilometers which represents 18 percent of the territory of the Russian Federation [36]. As of January 1, 2025, the population density of Yakutia was only 0.33 people per square

kilometer, one of the lowest in Russia [36]. The administrative center is the city of Yakutsk [36].

Regarding native speakers and ethnic composition, according to the 2020 All Russian Population Census, representatives of more than 120 nationalities live in Yakutia [36]. Based on the results of the same census for the city of Yakutsk, the most numerous ethnic groups were Sakha (Yakuts) at 59.2 percent and Russians at 26.4 percent, with smaller percentages of Kyrgyz, Evenki, Tajiks, Chinese, Armenians, Buryats, Evens, Ukrainians, Tatars, and Yukaghirs [36]. A 2026 scientific publication on indigenous small numbered peoples of Yakutia, based on the 2020 census data, reported that the total number of indigenous small numbered peoples of the North in Yakutia is 41,933 people [36]. The Evenki number 24,323 people and the Evens number 13,233 people, together comprising almost 90 percent of this group [36]. In terms of geographical features, the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia) is located in the northeastern part of the Asian continent and borders the Trans Baikal, Krasnoyarsk, and Khabarovsk territories, as well as the Irkutsk, Amur, and Magadan regions, and the Chukotka Autonomous Okrug [36]. The republic is part of the Far Eastern Federal District [36].

In the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia), the Russian and Yakut languages possess equal legal status as state languages, yet their actual functioning within the communicative space differs significantly [14]. A sociolinguistic analysis conducted from 2007 to 2016 reveals a consistently high functional status of the Russian language alongside insufficient functioning of the Yakut component of state bilingualism [14, p. 45]. The social functions of the two state languages exist in a relationship of functional complementarity, meaning they are distributed across different spheres of communication [14, p. 52]. In official public communication, within the system of state administrative management and record keeping, the Russian language predominates [14, p. 58]. In the education sector, out of 652 schools, 280 schools conduct instruction entirely in Russian, covering more than 60 percent of students, whereas instruction in Yakut is provided only in elementary and middle school across 368 schools, covering approximately 40 percent of students, with all instruction transitioning to Russian at the senior high school level [14, p. 67]. In the mass media, the social functions of Russian and Yakut are formally equal, but Russian prevails in terms of broadcasting volume [14, p. 72]. In unregulated spheres of communication, language distribution is primarily determined by the ethnic composition of the population [14, p. 78]. In monoethnic rural districts, the Yakut language dominates, whereas in industrial centers and the capital city of Yakutsk, which is home to one third of the republic's population, the Russian language prevails [14, p. 81]. At the same time, in the city of Yakutsk, a moderate increase in the use of Yakut in informal communication spheres has been observed, and among the Yakut population there is a growing tendency toward bilingualism with an increasing role of the native language in child rearing and education, facilitated by the urbanization of Yakuts and the rise of national consciousness [15, p. 112]. However, among Yakut youth, a possible sharp decline in native language competence is projected under the influence of globalization and digitalization, necessitating state support [15, p. 128]. Language distribution is determined by five main factors, namely the ethnic composition of the territory, the degree of state language policy involvement, urbanization and age, the type of professional activity, and established

stereotypes of language choice in urban discourse [14, p. 95]. The author emphasizes that the Russian language, knowledge of which is necessary for all citizens of the Russian Federation, should be acquired by children not instead of their ethnic language but alongside it, and advocates for the state level promotion of the global scientific community's position regarding the cultural and psychological advantages of bilingualism over monolingualism [14, p. 102].

The article by Sharina analyzes the modern language policy regarding minority languages of the indigenous small numbered peoples of the North living in Yakutia, specifically the Dolgan, Evenk, Even, Chukchi, and Yukagir [31]. The author notes that according to their social and functional parameters, these languages belong to languages with a low level of vitality and need special support [31, p. 35]. The linguistic situation among these peoples has formed under the influence of two main factors, the territorial dialectal factor and the ethnosocial factor [31, p. 36]. Among the positive characteristics of language policy in the republic are the presence of a developed legal framework regulating language practice, ideological support, and general favorability toward preserving endangered languages at the regional and local levels [31, p. 38]. However, the author also points to serious shortcomings, such as imperfect administrative regulation where authority over language policy is transferred between six different agencies, as well as extremely low funding for constructive projects aimed at language revitalization [31, p. 40]. The use of native languages in the education system demonstrates their consistently low status [31, p. 42]. The study of indigenous languages is conducted in only 37 stationary schools and 10 nomadic schools, in most of them for just one hour per week as an elective [31, p. 43]. Children receive instruction in the language of upbringing and education in only two kindergartens and two elementary schools using the Even language [31, p. 44]. Textbooks remain aimed at students with high language competence and do not meet new educational standards [31, p. 45]. The author also notes the absence of mechanisms to stimulate the study of minority languages, which prevents raising their social prestige [31, p. 46]. Funding under the state program for language development is unbalanced, with the majority of funds directed toward the Yakut language [31, p. 47]. Furthermore, there is a tendency to use borrowed graphic and orthographic norms under the influence of the Yakut language, which is unacceptable for speakers living in other regions [31, p. 48]. Indigenous languages are weakly represented in the media, with broadcast time reduced to two hours per week, and full internet presence is only beginning to develop thanks to individual activists and projects [31, p. 49]. In conclusion, the author states that despite declared support, the threat of extinction of small languages remains and requires the adoption of comprehensive measures, including the introduction of instruction at all levels of education, the creation of social mobility opportunities for native speakers, and the development of a separate state program for the revitalization of endangered languages [31, p. 50].

Then, the position of the English language in the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia) was investigated. In the Republic of Sakha (Yakutia), the English language occupies a distinct position within the multilingual landscape, functioning not merely as a foreign language for international communication but also as a symbolic resource in the urban space [30]. In the

capital city of Yakutsk, English ranks second in terms of representation after Russian in the linguistic landscape, yet its use is predominantly symbolic and decorative rather than informative [30, p. 45]. A study of urban signage in Yakutsk found that English appears on 31.8 percent of signs, but 85 percent of these instances are complementary, where languages supplement each other with different information, and the English language often serves a decorative function, perceived as a picture or "speech scenery" in the life of the townspeople rather than as a verbal unit intended for communication [30, p. 48]. This symbolic function is further evidenced by the frequent use of different fonts and designer styling for English words, as well as numerous examples of Russian-English code switching and mixing in commercial signs, such as "Pekarnia 'Bakery Street'" and "Magazin 'Original'", or orthographic hybridization like "Kachokgym" [30, p. 52].

In the educational domain, English is studied as the first foreign language in secondary schools across Yakutia and as a second foreign language at the university level [26]. At North-Eastern Federal University in Yakutsk, students who are bilingual in Russian and Sakha (Yakut) and who major in an Oriental language (Japanese, Chinese, or Korean) study English as a second foreign language, facing specific difficulties related to the typological differences between these languages and the requirements for mastering the educational material [26, p. 3]. Research has also shown that the ethnic identity and cultural background of students from the Sakha region significantly impact their English language learning, suggesting that intercultural communication and knowledge of the cultural features of the target language are prerequisites for effective acquisition [25]. A model of multilingual education has been developed in the Sakha Republic that is characterized by the systematic integration of language teaching and is aimed at achieving functional bilingualism and multilingualism, with the in-depth study of English as a foreign language built on parity bilingualism between the native Sakha language and Russian [26]. Furthermore, contemporary pedagogical approaches emphasize the formation of communicative competence in students learning English by incorporating ethnocultural traditions of the Sakha people and linguocultural material about the region into the educational process, thereby fostering the ability to engage in successful dialogue with representatives of other nationalities while respecting regional educational specificities [32].

1.4. Comparative Analysis of Tatarstan and Yakutia

The comparative analysis of Tatarstan and Yakutia reveals fundamental differences in their language status, type of bilingualism, and demographic characteristics of speaker communities [37]. Both republics recognize Russian as a state language alongside their titular languages, Tatar in Tatarstan and Sakha (Yakut) in Yakutia [7]. However, Yakutia presents a more complex legal framework by granting official status to five indigenous languages of the North, including Evenki, Even, Yukaghir, Dolgan, and Chukchi, in places of their compact residence [6]. In terms of bilingualism, Tatarstan exhibits a balanced Russian Tatar model that is increasingly splitting into two distinct linguistic communities, a Russian speaking urban population and a declining Tatar speaking rural population [37]. Yakutia, by contrast, has undergone a historical transition from Yakut indigenous bilingualism to a complex trilingual

model involving Yakut, Russian, and indigenous languages, though the functioning of Even, Evenki, and Yukaghir is now minimal, with Yukaghir approaching extinction [31]. Regarding speaker demography, Tatarstan's rural Tatar speaking population is experiencing demographic decline while the Russian speaking urban population remains stable [37]. In Yakutia, the total population is approximately 970,000 people with Yakuts comprising about half, while indigenous small numbered peoples number over 40,000 but show critically low and declining linguistic competence [36]. The following table summarizes these key differences.

After exploring two regions, we made a comparison table of Tatarstan and Yakutia (**Table 1.**)

Table 1.
Comparison of Tatarstan and Yakutia

Aspect	Tatarstan	Yakutia
Language Status	Russian and Tatar hold equal legal status as state languages with active monitoring of language legislation in 2026[37].	Sakha (Yakut) and Russian are the two state languages, while five indigenous languages (Evenki, Even, Yukaghir, Dolgan, Chukchi) have official status in places of compact residence[6] .
Type of Bilingualism	Balanced Russian Tatar bilingualism is increasingly splitting into two distinct linguistic communities: a Russian speaking urban population and a Tatar speaking rural population [37].	The region has transitioned from Yakut indigenous bilingualism to a complex trilingual model involving Yakut, Russian, and indigenous languages, though Even, Evenki, and Yukaghir functioning is now minimal[31].
Demography of Speakers	The rural Tatar speaking population is experiencing demographic decline while the Russian speaking urban population remains more stable[37].	The total population is approximately 970,000 people with Yakuts comprising about half, and indigenous small numbered peoples number over 40,000 but with critically low and declining linguistic competence[36].

Overall, the comparative analysis of Tatarstan and Yakutia reveals two distinct models of multilingualism that will directly inform the practical construction and interpretation of the code-switching graph [36]. In Tatarstan, the linguistic environment is characterized by balanced but diverging Russian Tatar bilingualism, where the graph is expected to show a

dense cluster of Tatar speaking users in rural areas, a separate Russian speaking urban cluster, and a relatively small number of bridging users with high degree centrality who actively switch between both languages [37]. The direction of switching is predicted to be asymmetric, with more frequent transitions from Russian to Tatar in official and educational contexts, and the opposite direction in informal family and community settings [12]. The presence of English as a third language, driven by growing demand for business English and international economic ties, is likely to appear in the graph as isolated nodes or small clusters, indicating that English functions more as a symbolic or professional resource rather than an integrated part of daily digital communication [18].

In Yakutia, the linguistic landscape is more fragmented, with a complex trilingual model involving Yakut, Russian, and several endangered indigenous languages such as Evenki, Even, and Yukaghir [31]. The graph for Yakutia is expected to show a high degree of centralization around Russian, with Yakut forming a secondary cluster that is more prominent in rural and unofficial communication channels [14]. Indigenous languages, given their critically low speaker base and minimal presence in education and media, are likely to appear as peripheral nodes or isolates with very few connections, reflecting their endangered status [31]. The graph may also reveal that code-switching in Yakutia is predominantly unidirectional toward Russian, with limited reverse switching, indicating ongoing language shift [31]. Unlike Tatarstan, where English serves a growing practical function, English in Yakutia is expected to appear predominantly in symbolic and decorative roles, as evidenced by its presence on urban signage where it functions as "speech scenery" rather than as a communicative tool [30]. The practical construction of the directed graph will thus not only visualize these patterns but also allow for quantitative analysis of degree centrality to identify users who act as linguistic bridges, cluster analysis to detect language isolates, and keyword analysis to identify trigger words such as "әйе" (yes in Tatar), "эһэ" (yes in Yakut), or "алло" (hello) that most frequently initiate switching [18]. The comparison between the two republics will ultimately show that Tatarstan exhibits a more integrated but stratified bilingual structure with emerging trilingual elements, while Yakutia demonstrates a hierarchical multilingual structure dominated by Russian with peripheral indigenous languages under significant threat of extinction [37]. These findings will provide empirical evidence for how state language policies, demographic pressures, and digital communication practices interact to shape code-switching behavior in the multilingual regions of Russia.

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